Classical repertoire

Real pieces by Bach, Mozart, Beethoven and Pachelbel, simplified for you.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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1. Minuet in G, part 1

The famous minuet from the Anna Magdalena Notebook.

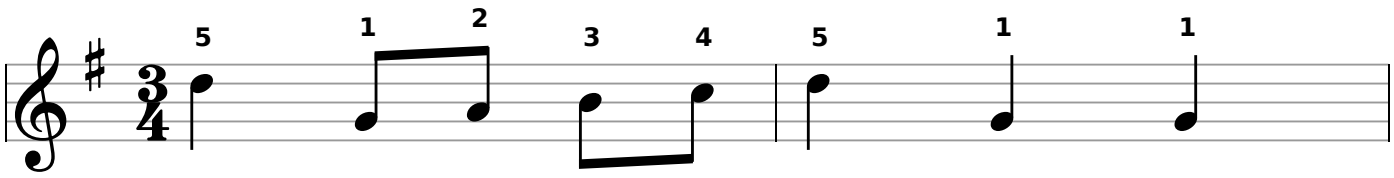
A dance from 1725

This minuet appears in a notebook Johann Sebastian Bach gave his wife, Anna Magdalena. It was long credited to Bach, but was most likely written by **Christian Petzold**. Either way, almost every piano student plays it.

A minuet is a graceful dance in **3/4**. The key is **G major**, so every F is F♯. The fingering shown is a suggestion. Your hand will shift position a few times, so watch the numbers.

Practise · Bars 1 to 4

Right hand. The eighth notes are twice as fast as the quarter notes.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bars 5 to 8

Now the second phrase, ending on a long A.

Practise · Part 1 complete

All eight bars, right hand.
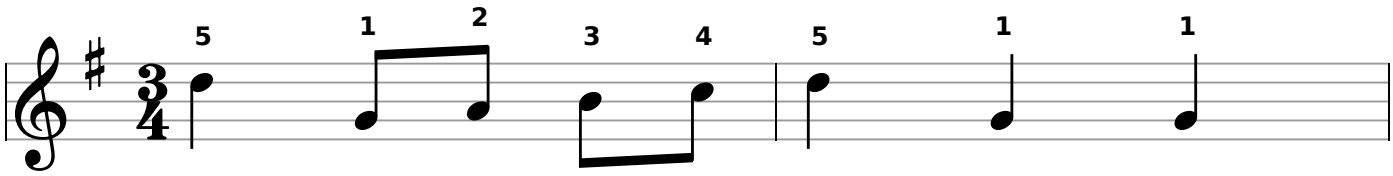
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2. Minuet in G, part 2

The second half, then hands together.

Practise · Second ending

The music repeats, but this time it ends on G: home.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

A simple left hand

Here's a simplified left hand: one long note per bar (a dotted half note, three beats). It traces the harmony underneath the melody.

Practice the left hand alone first, then put them together very slowly.

Practise · Left hand alone

One note per bar. Hold each for three beats.

Practise · Minuet in G, hands together

Both hands. The app waits on every beat where both hands play.

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3. Eine kleine Nachtmusik

Mozart's famous opening, in G major.
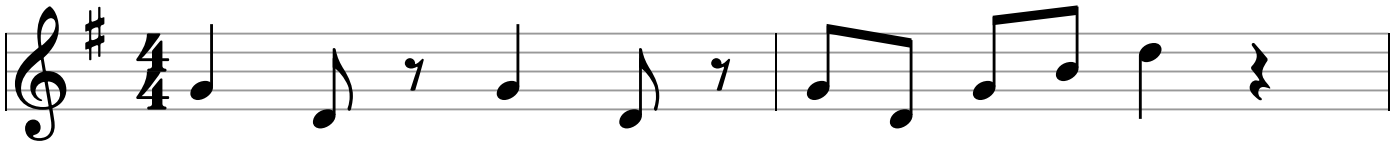
A little night music

Mozart wrote **Eine kleine Nachtmusik** ("A Little Night Music") in 1787 for strings. Its opening is one of the most recognizable bits of music ever.

It's built entirely from the **G major chord** (G B D) and then a **D major chord** (D F♯ A). Notice the short rests: they give it its crisp, cheeky feel.

Practise · The opening

Play crisply. Short notes, clean rests.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

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4. Sixteenth notes and 3/8

Four notes in a beat, and the time signature of Für Elise.

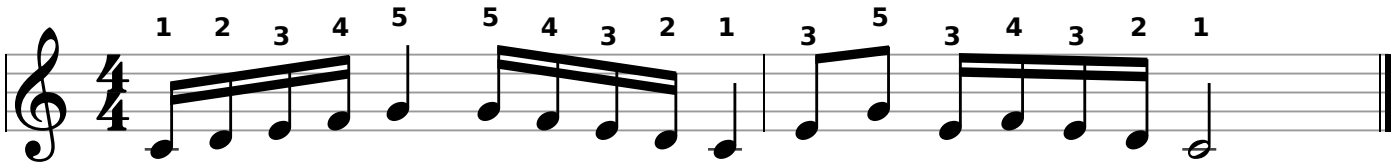
Four to a beat

A **sixteenth note** has two flags, or two beams when they're grouped. Four of them fit into one beat. Count them "**1** e and a, **2** e and a".

Practise them slowly and evenly. Speed comes later, by itself.

Practise · Even sixteenths

Say "1 e and a" for the quick notes, and keep them all the same length.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

3/8 time

3/8 means three eighth notes per bar. It goes by quickly, so it's usually felt as **one beat per bar**, with a little lilt.

Beethoven wrote **Für Elise** in 3/8, and its famous opening is all sixteenth notes. This warm-up gets your fingers ready.

Practise · A 3/8 warm-up

Three eighths in each bar. The sixteenths come in fours, filling two eighths.

5. Für Elise

Beethoven's most famous piano piece: the opening theme.

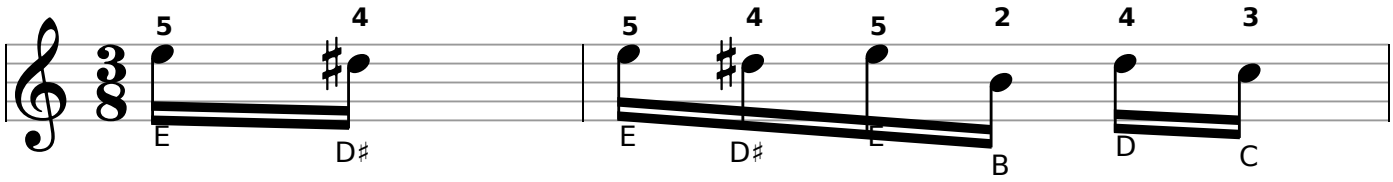
For Elise

Beethoven wrote **Für Elise** around 1810. Nobody is quite sure who Elise was! It's in **A minor** and in **3/8** time: three eighth-note beats per bar.

The famous opening rocks between **E** and **D♯** (the black key just below E). Then the melody falls down to A, and the hands share a rising broken chord.

Practise · The E–D♯ turn

Just the opening: E D♯ E D♯ E B D C, then A. Fingers 5 4 5 4 5 2 4 3, then 1.



Opening example · 3/8 · Am · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Opening theme, right hand

The whole opening theme, right hand. The keyboard shows you where each note is.

Adding the left hand

In the gaps, the left hand plays three quick notes: **A E A** under the A bars and **E E G♯** under the B bar. The right hand then continues the rising line.

Notice how the two hands take turns, like a conversation.

Practise · Für Elise, hands together

Hands take turns. Go slowly and let each note ring.

6. Prelude in C

Bach's flowing broken chords, simplified.

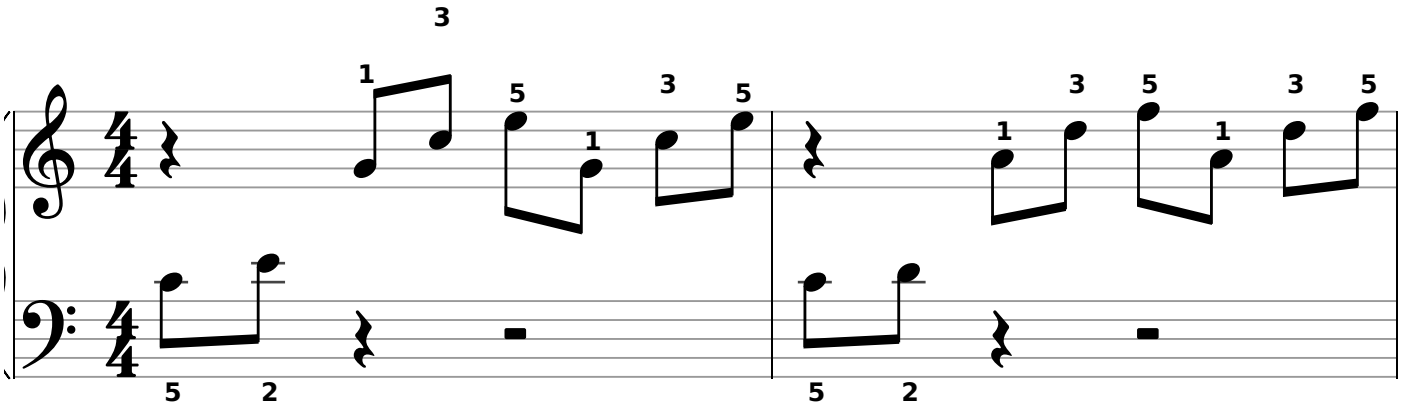
The Well-Tempered Clavier

This prelude opens Bach's **Well-Tempered Clavier** (1722). The whole piece is one pattern: each bar is a chord, broken into flowing notes.

In this simplified version the left hand plays the first two notes of each bar, and the right hand plays the top three notes twice. Let the notes ring into each other.

Practise · Bars 1 to 4

Left hand starts each bar with two notes, then the right hand takes over.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Prelude in C, bars 1 to 8

All eight bars. Smooth and even, like water.

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7. Pachelbel's Canon

The famous melody over the chords you learned.

Melody meets harmony

You learned the Canon's chords in the Harmony unit. Its most famous line is a slow, falling melody: **E D C B A G A B**, one note per chord.

Here the right hand plays that melody while the left hand plays the roots. Listen to how each melody note fits its chord.

Practise · The melody alone

Slow half notes. Sing it as you play.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Pachelbel's Canon

Hands together. Play it twice: once as written, once even more gently.

8. Schumann: Melody

The first piece in his Album for the Young.

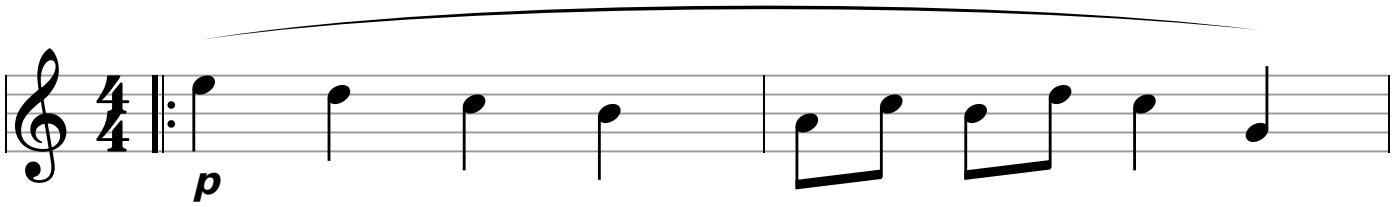
Album for the Young

Robert Schumann wrote his **Album for the Young** (1848) for his daughters to play. "Melody" is the very first piece: a gentle tune over a flowing left hand.

Here you'll play the tune. Keep it **legato** under each slur, and lift gently at the end of each phrase like a singer breathing. The first four bars repeat. The music moves around the keyboard, so choose comfortable fingers and let your hand travel.

Practise · Melody, right hand

Soft and singing. The first line plays twice, then the music climbs and comes home.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

9. Mozart: Minuet in F

Written by Mozart when he was five years old.

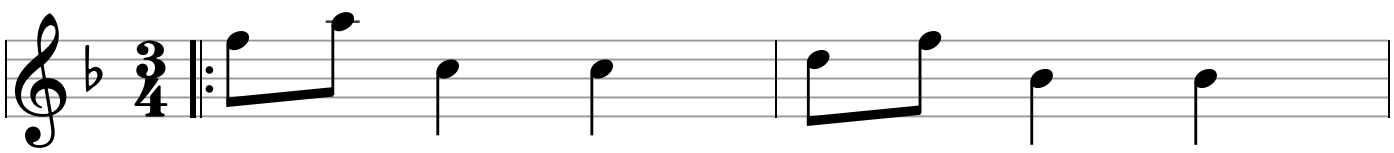
A five-year-old composer

Mozart wrote this **Minuet in F** (K. 2) in 1762, when he was just five. His father wrote it down in his sister Nannerl's music book.

It's in **F major** (B♭ in the key signature) and 3/4. The first half repeats. Each little phrase starts with two quick notes that skip up, then two quarter notes: **short-short long long**. This version keeps Mozart's melody and the lowest note of his bass.

Practise · First half, right hand [F]

Eight bars, played twice. Feel the dance: ONE two three.



Opening example · 3/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Second half, right hand [F]

A darker turn with E♭ and F♯, then the opening returns twice to finish.

Practise · The bass line [F]

Left hand alone. Mostly long notes, with a few walking quarter notes at the cadences.

Practise · Minuet in F, hands together [F]

Both hands, slowly. The app waits for you.

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10. Clementi: Sonatina in C

The bright opening of every piano student's favourite sonatina.

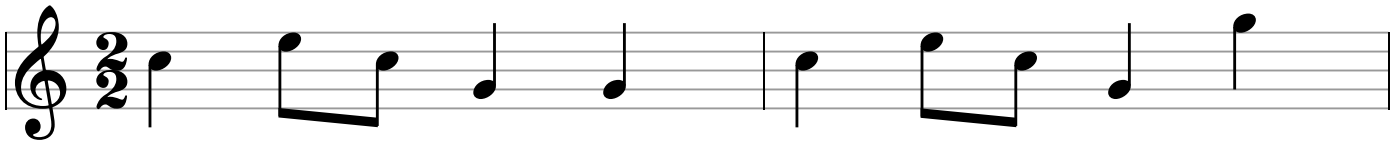
The sonatina

A **sonatina** is a "little sonata". Muzio Clementi's Op. 36 sonatinas (1797) have been played by piano students for over two hundred years, and No. 1 in C is the first of them.

It opens with a cheerful broken chord, answered by quick running notes. It's in **cut time** (2/2): two half-note beats in a bar, so it moves along briskly once you know it. Try it bright and confident, with the running eighths smooth and even.

Practise · Right hand, bars 1 to 8

Start slowly. Bright on the broken chords, smooth on the running eighths.



Opening example · 2/2 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand, bars 1 to 8

The left hand mostly marks the start of each bar. Count the rests.

Practise · Hands together

Both hands, as slowly as you need.

11. The complete Doxology

The whole hymn in G, hands together, with its Amen.

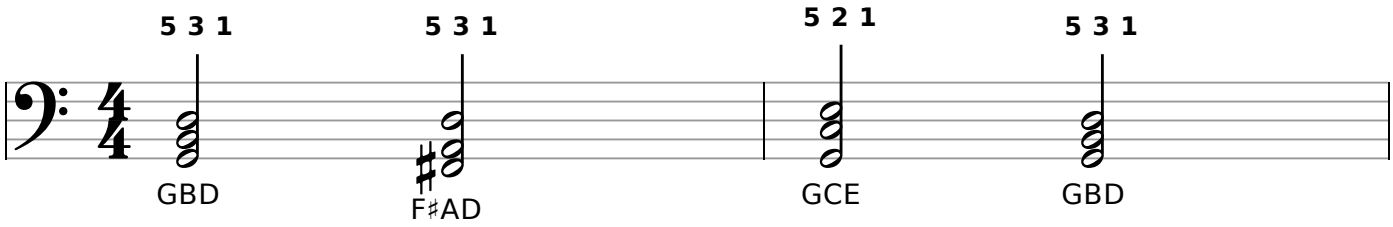
The whole hymn

This is where the Doxology has been heading: the **complete hymn**, in the hymnal key of G major, with both hands, phrasing and dynamics, and the **Amen** at the end.

The left-hand chords are G, C and D, played as inversions so your hand hardly moves. The Amen is the "church" ending: a C chord resolving to G.

Practise · Left hand alone

All four lines of chords and the Amen. Let your hand stay in one place: G stays under finger 5 except for the D chord.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 1 and 2, hands together

Melody on top, chords soft underneath.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4, and Amen

Quiet third line, growing into the last. Then a slow, gentle Amen.

Practise · The complete Doxology

The whole hymn, both hands, no keyboard hints. Play it like you're leading a congregation.

12. What comes next

How to keep improving.

You did it

You've gone from finding Middle C to playing Bach, Mozart and Beethoven. That's a real achievement.

Some habits that keep you improving:

- **Little and often.** 15 minutes every day beats two hours on Sunday.
- **Warm up with scales** (C, G and F major, and A minor) before your pieces.
- **Practice slowly.** Speed comes by itself once the notes are secure.
- **Hands separately first**, then together.
- **Replay old lessons.** Try them with the keyboard hints off and the names hidden.

Going further

When you're ready, look for these classic beginner books and pieces. They're all public domain and freely available online:

- Bach: more pieces from the **Anna Magdalena Notebook** (Minuet in G minor, Musette in D)
- Clementi: **Sonatina in C, Op. 36 No. 1**
- Schumann: **Album for the Young** ("Melody", "Soldier's March")
- Burgmüller: **25 Easy Studies, Op. 100**

A teacher, even for a few lessons, is the best way to check your posture and technique. Enjoy the journey!

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13. Joyful, Joyful (grand finale)

The hymn you learned in unit 2, now with a full classical accompaniment.

Your graduation piece

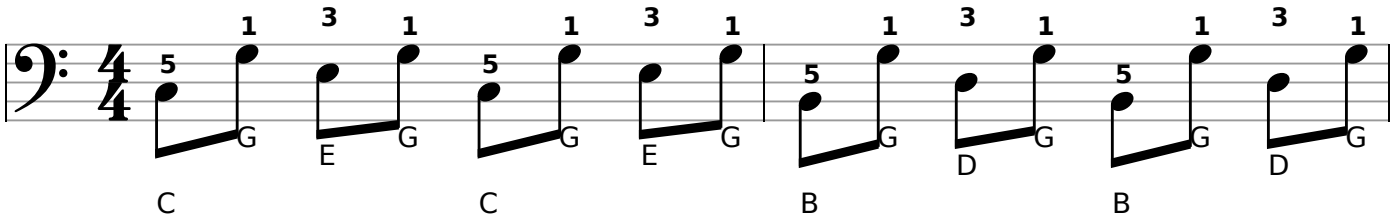
For your final recital, you'll return to **"Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee"**, but played the way a pianist would play it in church or a concert.

- The right hand plays the melody **an octave higher**, so it rings out brightly.
- The left hand plays a flowing **Alberti bass** (bottom, top, middle, top), switching between **C** and **G** chords.

Compare where you started in unit 2 with this. That's how far you've come.

Practise · Left hand alone

The Alberti pattern for the first line: C chord, G chord, C chord, G chord.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 1, hands together

Right hand starts on the E above the C an octave over Middle C.

Practise · The middle line, hands together

Chords change every two beats here. Go slowly.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole hymn, both hands, with hints.

Practise · Your final recital

Your graduation performance. No hints, steady and proud. Enjoy it!

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14. The complete Doxology

The whole hymn in G, both hands, with its Amen.

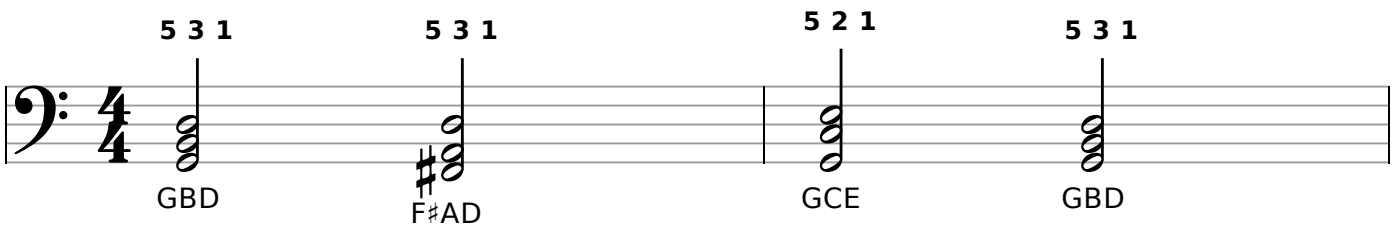
The whole hymn

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The left-hand chords are G, C and D, played as inversions so your hand hardly moves. The Amen is the "church" ending: a C chord resolving to G.

Practise · Left hand alone

All four lines of chords and the Amen. Let your hand stay in one place: G stays under finger 5 except for the D chord.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 1 and 2, hands together

Melody on top, chords soft underneath.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4, and Amen

Quiet third line, growing into the last. Then a slow, gentle Amen.

Practise · Your recital

The whole Doxology, both hands, with its Amen. Play it like you're leading a congregation.

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15. Mozart: Sonata in C (opening)

The famous first four bars of Mozart's "easy" sonata, K. 545.

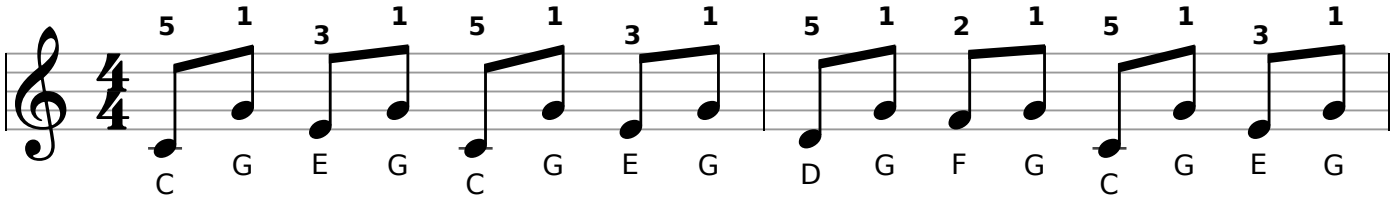
The "easy" sonata

Mozart wrote his **Piano Sonata in C, K. 545** in 1788 "for beginners". It's one of the most famous openings in piano music.

Here are its first four bars. The right hand plays a singing melody, with a quick **sixteenth-note** turn at the end of bars 2 and 4. The left hand plays an **Alberti bass** around Middle C: bottom, top, middle, top.

Practise · Left hand alone

Alberti bass, bottom, top, middle, top. Keep it soft and even.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Right hand alone

Sing the melody. The sixteenths are quick but light.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

Both hands, with hints. Melody on top, left hand quieter.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Read the key, time signature, and patterns before starting a piece.
- ☐ Count sixteenth notes slowly before increasing speed.
- ☐ Practise a difficult passage with separate hands, then together.
- ☐ Perform a chosen piece with steady rhythm, phrasing, and a clear melody, then describe what to improve.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
